

Multi-Functional Printers: The Workflow Managers of Modern Workplaces

Gone are the days when printers just printed. Modern-day printers can do much more than what you expected five years ago. This article explores how multi-functional printers evolved and why you should consider buying them.

Multi-functional printers, commonly known as MFPs, have become the order of the day. With time, MFPs have evolved and reached a point where they can be complete productivity solutions that help businesses improve their workflow.

The demand for MFPs is increasing as they have an additional edge (with respect to functionality) over single function devices. Companies dealing with these products have reported increased adoption by small, medium-sized businesses as well as large enterprises. The primary factors leading to MFP adoption include higher levels of efficiency, lower total cost of ownership, high quality prints, ease of use and the overall value they offer. Multifunction colour laser printers possess true multitasking abilities, while also offering users the competitive advantage of colour, when work demands it.

Modern day MFPs have built-in capabilities that enable printing from the cloud and from mobile devices. MFPs now help workplaces of all sizes to significantly increase productivity and sustainability. They are also true enablers of the BYOD practice since they now have outstanding security features.

But should you invest in MFPs when they are more expensive than regular printers? You can answer this all-important question after a bit of analysis at your end. A few important things you must keep in mind before you make the final choice are listed below.

1. Evaluate your needs: Commenting on the points to consider while buying an MFP, Nitin Hiranandani, director, Printing Systems, PPS, HP India, says, "The first thing that one should look at is one's requirements. Understanding the need of the end user is of prime importance. Also, knowing how exactly you can use the MFP to manage your documents, simplify workflow and reduce paper use is important. You should know how many print, copy, fax and email jobs you

would need on a daily basis. Also, arrive at an estimate on how many users will share the device and whether or not they need a colour capable device."

Ideally, MFPs can be categorised based on their intended use, which is broadly—office or home. If you are looking to buy an MFP for your home, you probably would want to opt for a photo quality device, which means, you should go for an inkjet model. Besides, if you love photography and want to print photographs from all sources including your camera, USB drive, memory cards, et al, you need a photo-lab MFP. If you are looking for a device specifically for an office set-up, your documents are likely to have more text than photos, which means that a laser-class printer is the one for you. The device will help you fax and email, and includes an automatic document feeder (ADF) to scan, copy, fax and email multi-page documents.

However, if you are looking for a device for both home and office purposes, an inkjet MFP is the right choice for you, for the photo quality that it offers, along with its office-centric features like an ADF and fax modem.

2. What features do you want? An MFP can offer a wide array of features. So it is advisable to make a list of features that you want. Hiranandani asserts, "It's a given that an MFP will offer features like printing, scanning and copying, but these features may not be as straightforward as one may think. Some MFPs have restrictions on scanning over a USB connection. So, if you plan to connect your MFP to a network connection, ensure that the scanning function works on the network too."

Some MFPs require a computer for copying. In case you want to copy documents without the computer, ensure that the MFP can work as a standalone copier. When it comes to faxing by an MFP, it operates as a standalone device, in most cases, with the user having control through the MFP's keypad.

